StartHere — UX Spec

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Overview

StartHere is a mobile app that gives people 60+ one calm place to check anything suspicious and ask an AI coach for help, with family looped in when it matters. Its whole UX answers one question for the user: **"Is this safe, and what do I do next?"**

Primary user. "Dorothy," 72, lives alone, has a smartphone she mostly uses for calls, texts and photos of grandkids. She gets 3 to 5 scam texts or calls a week and doesn't know which are real. She's embarrassed to keep asking her kids.

Secondary user. "Mark," 45, her son. Lives two states away. Wants to know if Mom is about to wire money to a stranger, without hovering over her phone.

UX goals

Goal	What it means on screen	Success measure (pilot)
Get to a verdict fast	Any suspicious item checked in 3 taps or one spoken sentence	Median time to verdict under 30 seconds
Never leave her stuck	Every verdict ends in one clear next action	90%+ of checks end on a next-step tap
Build confidence, not fear	Calm language, praise for checking	Self-reported confidence up after 2 weeks
Keep family close, not controlling	Alerts only on high-risk events she agreed to	Fewer than 2 family alerts per week on average
Work without reading glasses	Large type, voice in and out everywhere	Usability test: task success with no help

Design principles

Six rules govern every screen; when a design choice is unclear, these decide it.

1. **One job per screen.** One headline, one primary button. Secondary actions sit below as text links.

2. **Big and high-contrast.** Body text 20pt minimum, headlines 28pt+, buttons 64pt tall and full width. Contrast 7:1 (WCAG AAA). Respect the phone's system text size up to 200%.
3. **Voice first, touch always.** A large microphone button is on every main screen. Everything the app says can be read aloud. Nothing requires voice.
4. **Plain words.** 6th-grade reading level. No jargon ("phishing," "URL," "2FA") without a plain explanation beside it.
5. **Calm, never scary.** Even a scam verdict is delivered steadily: what it is, that she's safe because she checked, what to do now. No flashing red, no alarm sounds.
6. **Nothing hidden, nothing irreversible.** No swipe gestures, no long-press, no hamburger menus. Every action has a visible Back and an Undo or confirm step.

Visual system (starter)

Element	Spec
Base	Warm off-white background, near-black text
Safe	Deep green + check icon + the word "Looks safe"
Caution	Amber + question icon + "Be careful"
Scam	Deep red + stop-hand icon + "This is a scam"
Color rule	Color never carries meaning alone: always icon + word
Tap targets	64 x 64pt minimum, 16pt spacing between
Motion	None beyond simple fades; honor Reduce Motion

Information architecture

Four tabs, labeled with words and icons, always visible at the bottom. Home is the default and holds the two biggest buttons in the app.

Tab	Icon + label	What lives here
1	House · **Home**	"Check something" button, "Ask my coach" button, today's tip, family status line

Tab	Icon + label	What lives here
2	Shield · **Check**	Scam Checker: paste, share, photo, or describe a call; history of past checks
3	Chat bubble · **Coach**	AI Coach conversation, voice and text
4	Book · **Learn**	Guided lessons and progress

Family and Settings open from a person icon at top right of Home, not a tab, so the main bar stays at four.

Screen inventory (MVP)

#	Screen	Reached from	Priority
1	Welcome + voice setup	First launch	Must
2	Add family member	Onboarding, Family	Must
3	Home	Tab 1	Must
4	Check: choose input	Home, Tab 2, share sheet	Must
5	Check: analyzing	After input	Must
6	Verdict (Safe / Careful / Scam)	After analysis	Must
7	Stop screen (high-risk interrupt)	Verdict = Scam with money or codes	Must
8	Check history	Tab 2	Should
9	Coach conversation	Home, Tab 3, any verdict	Must
10	Lesson list	Tab 4	Should
11	Lesson player	Lesson list, Coach suggestion	Should
12	Family circle + safe word	Person icon	Must
13	Family member view (Mark's app)	Invite link	Should
14	Settings: text size, voice, privacy	Person icon	Must

Onboarding

Onboarding is five screens, under 3 minutes, and skippable after screen 2. No account password: sign-in by phone number and a texted code, or Apple/Google sign-in.

1. **Welcome.** "Hi, I'm your StartHere coach. I help you spot scams and figure out technology, one step at a time." Buttons: **Get started** / *A family member is helping me*.
2. **How should I talk to you?** Pick text size by tapping the sample that reads comfortably (3 sizes shown live). Toggle "Read things out loud to me" (default on). Pick a voice from 2 options with a play button each.
3. **What should I call you?** First name only, typed or spoken.
4. **Add someone you trust (optional).** Name + phone number of one family member. Plain explanation: "If something looks like a scam involving money, I can let them know. You're always in control." Buttons: **Add them** / *Maybe later*.
5. **Permissions, one at a time, each with a reason.** Notifications ("so I can warn you about a risky message"), microphone ("so you can talk instead of type"). Never ask for contacts, location or SMS access at launch.

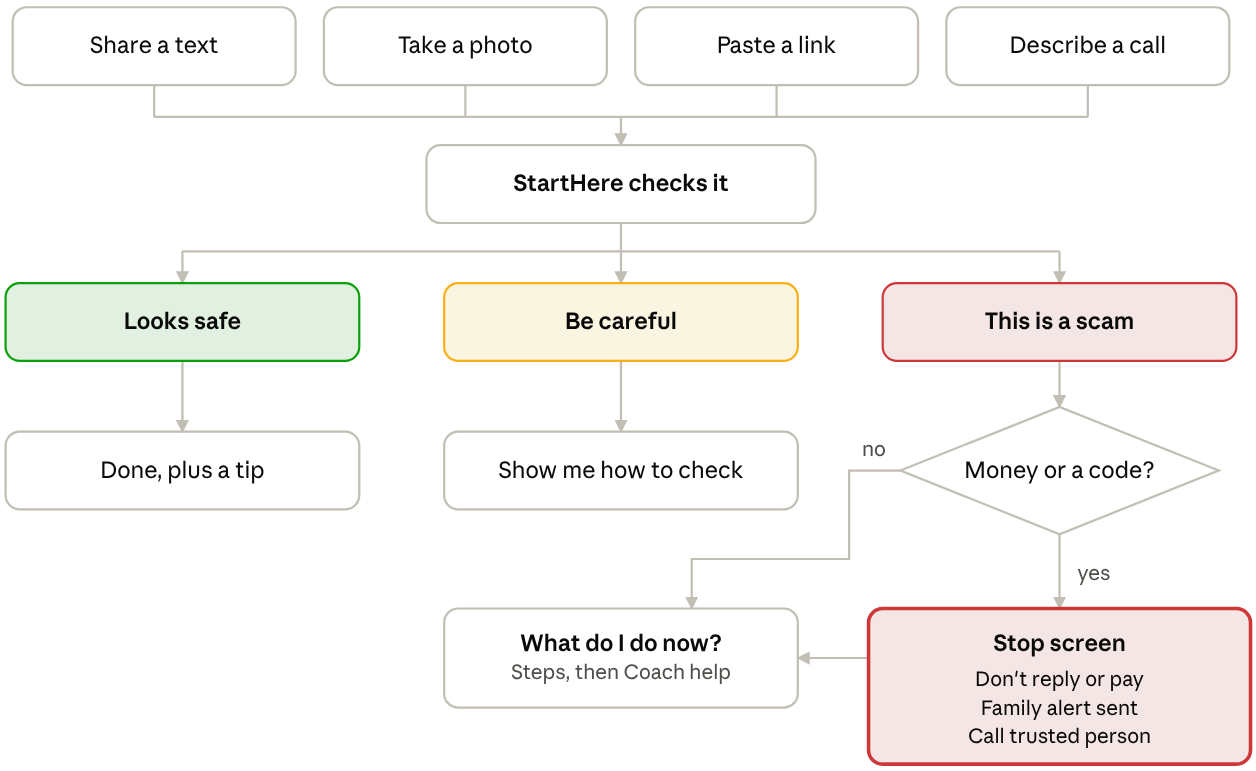
End state: Home, with a coach bubble: "Try it: tap **Check something** and show me a text you weren't sure about."

A family member is helping me runs the same flow with copy addressed to the helper ("Set this up for your mom") and hands the phone back at the end.

Scam Checker

The Scam Checker is the hero feature: any suspicious item goes in, a plain verdict and one next step come out. A scam that asks for money or a code jumps straight to a full-screen Stop.

Every check ends in one next step; money or code scams hit Stop



Scam Checker flow · 4 inputs, 3 verdicts, 1 high-risk interrupt

Inputs (screen 4). Four big tiles, each with an icon and a one-line hint:

- **Share a text** — from Messages or Mail via the phone's share button (the main path; teach it in onboarding).
- **Take a photo** — of a letter, a screen, a pop-up on the computer.
- **Paste a link** — or a phone number, or an email address.
- **Describe a call** — tap the mic and tell the Coach what the caller said.

Analyzing (screen 5). Calm progress message, not a spinner alone: "Reading the message… Looking for warning signs…" with an animated check that respects Reduce Motion.

Verdict (screen 6). Top to bottom: verdict icon + word in its color, headline, "Here's why" with up to 3 plain signs ("It asks for a code. Real banks never do this."), then one primary button and a *Talk to my Coach* link. A speaker icon reads the whole verdict aloud.

Stop screen (screen 7). Full screen, deep red band at top, stop-hand icon. Three numbered instructions: 1. Don't reply. 2. Don't send money, gift cards or codes. 3. Call someone you trust. Big button: **Call Mark** (her trusted person). If the scam is a family-impostor type, it also shows: "Ask for your family safe word." A second button **I already replied or paid** opens a short recovery checklist (call the bank's real number, change the password, report it).

AI Coach

The Coach is a patient helper that answers one step at a time and waits for "done" before giving the next step. It is the same AI behind the Scam Checker, so she can move from a verdict straight into "what do I do now?"

Screen layout

- Top: "Your Coach" + a Stop talking button when audio is playing.
- Middle: conversation in large bubbles. Coach messages have a speaker icon to replay aloud.
- Bottom: a 72pt microphone button (center), a text box (left), and 3 suggestion chips that change with context, e.g. "Is this text real?", "Help me send a photo", "What is ChatGPT?"

Step-by-step mode. When she asks how to do something on her phone, the Coach answers with numbered steps shown one card at a time: one instruction, a picture of the button to press, and **Done, next step** / *I'm stuck*. *I'm stuck* rephrases the step more simply.

Voice. Tap once to talk, tap again to stop (no hold-to-talk). The Coach repeats back what it heard before acting on anything important: "You said the bank called about your card. Is that right?"

Guardrails

Situation	Coach behavior
She mentions sending money, gift cards, crypto or a code to someone	Pause, run a scam check on the situation, show the Stop screen if high risk
She asks for medical, legal or financial decisions	Give general info, suggest calling her doctor, lawyer or family

Situation	Coach behavior
She seems confused or upset	Slow down, shorter sentences, offer to call her trusted person
She asks the Coach to log into an account or enter passwords	Decline; explain it will never ask for passwords
Topic outside its knowledge	Say so plainly; never guess on safety questions

Trusted Family Circle

The senior owns the circle: she invites people, chooses what they see, and can remove anyone. Family members get alerts, never her messages, unless she taps "Share this with Mark."

Roles

Role	Who	Can do
Owner	The senior	Everything; sets what each person sees
Trusted person	1 to 3 family members or friends	Get high-risk alerts, see verdict summaries she shares, call her from the alert
Helper (optional)	One trusted person	Change her settings remotely, with her approval each time

What triggers an alert to family (her choice in settings; defaults shown)

- On by default: a Scam verdict involving money, gift cards, crypto, bank details or a verification code.
- On by default: she taps **Call my trusted person** from the Stop screen.
- Off by default: every check, including Safe ones (weekly summary instead).

Alert to family (push + SMS fallback): "Mom checked a text that looks like a bank-impersonation scam asking for a code. She was told not to reply. Tap to call her." Buttons: **Call Mom** / *See details*.

Family safe word. A shared word set in the circle. The app reminds her: "If someone calls claiming to be family in trouble, ask for the safe word." Shown on the Stop screen for impostor and grandparent scams. Stored on the device; the Coach never says it aloud unless she asks.

Family member view (Mark's app). Same app, a simpler "Helper" home: her status ("All quiet this week · 6 checks, 0 scams"), recent alerts, a call button, and a short lesson for him: "How to talk with Mom about scams without making her feel bad."

Guided Lessons

Lessons build skills that can be measured, not just completed. Each one states the skill it teaches, makes her practice it on realistic examples, and counts it as learned only after she shows she can do it without help.

Lesson structure (5 to 7 minutes)

1. **Skill goal.** One line on the first card: "By the end, you'll spot a fake bank text on your own."
2. **Teach (3 to 4 cards).** One sign or step per card, with a real-looking example and narration.
3. **Drill.** 5 realistic examples, one at a time. She sorts each one: **Safe** / **Be careful** / **Scam**, or does the real action (tap the right button, find the real number). Instant feedback on each: what she got right, and the sign she missed if she didn't.
4. **Result.** "You got 4 of 5. You can spot fake bank texts." Below 4 of 5: a short redo that covers only the signs she missed, then a fresh drill.

The feedback is factual and brief. No "Nice work" unless it's tied to a result.

Starter curriculum (MVP: 3 tracks, 8 lessons)

Track	Lesson	Skill she can show	Drill (pass = 4 of 5)
Stay safe	Spot a scam text	Sorts texts correctly without help	Sort 5 sample texts
Stay safe	Family-in-trouble calls	Asks for the safe word before acting	Choose the right reply in 5 call scripts
Stay safe	Fake bank and Medicare calls	Hangs up and calls the real number	Find the real number for 5 situations

Track	Lesson	Skill she can show	Drill (pass = 4 of 5)
Stay safe	Payment red flags	Recognizes gift card, crypto and wire requests	Sort 5 payment requests
Use AI	Ask AI a useful question	Asks a clear question and gets a usable answer	Rewrite 5 vague questions so they get better answers, then try one
Use AI	Talk to your phone	Completes tasks by voice	Do 5 voice tasks (weather, reminder, call, text, search)
Everyday tech	Send a photo	Sends a photo to a contact without steps on screen	Send 3 photos to the right person
Everyday tech	Video call family	Starts and ends a video call alone	Place one real call to her trusted person

Track skill check. After the last lesson in a track: a 10-item mixed drill pulled from every lesson in it. 8 of 10 = track mastered. Misses route her back to the specific lesson, not the whole track.

Keeping it. 7 days after she passes, the app brings back 2 to 3 drill items as a quick "Spot the scam" round on Home. 14 days later, again. A miss reopens that one lesson.

Progress view. A skill list, not a badge wall: each skill shows Learning, Passed or Mastered (passed + kept at both retests). No streaks or points.

Family view. Mark sees skills, not activity: "Can spot scam texts · Mastered. Family-call scams · Learning." This tells him where to help.

Copy and tone

The voice is a calm, respectful grandchild who happens to know tech: warm, brief, never condescending, never alarmist.

Do	Don't
"Good call checking this."	"Warning! Threat detected!"
"This is a scam. You're safe because you didn't reply."	"You almost got scammed."

Do	Don't
"Tap the green button."	"Navigate to the CTA."
"A link is the blue words you can tap."	"Don't click suspicious URLs."
"I'm not sure. Let's ask Mark."	Guessing on a safety question

Verdict templates

Verdict	Headline	Body pattern	Primary button
Looks safe	"This looks safe"	Why (1 line) + one caution if any	**Done**
Be careful	"Be careful with this one"	What's odd (up to 3 plain signs) + how to check it yourself	**Show me how to check**
Scam	"This is a scam"	What kind + the 1 to 3 signs + "You did the right thing"	**What do I do now?**

Error and empty states

- No internet: "I can't check right now because the internet is off. Don't reply to the message yet. I'll check as soon as you're back online."
- Can't read a photo: "That picture is a little blurry. Try again, holding the phone steady."
- Didn't catch voice: "Sorry, I didn't catch that. Try again, or type it."
- Empty history: "Nothing checked yet. When something seems off, tap **Check something**."

Accessibility, demo and handoff

Accessibility checklist (ship-blocking)

- [ ] Every screen works with VoiceOver and TalkBack; every button has a spoken label
- [ ] Dynamic Type / font scaling to 200% with no clipped text
- [ ] 7:1 contrast on text, 3:1 on icons; verified in dark mode
- [ ] 64pt tap targets; no gestures required
- [ ] Captions on all narrated lesson audio
- [ ] Tested with 5 users aged 65+ before demo day if possible

Demo script for judges (about 3 minutes, leads with the fraud story)

1. **The hook (30s).** A real-feeling text on screen: "Your Chase account is locked. Reply with the code we sent." One line of stakes: older adults lose billions a year to fraud, and most never report it out of embarrassment.
2. **Check it (45s).** Dorothy taps Share, sends the text to StartHere. Verdict: "This is a scam." The Stop screen appears because it asks for a code.
3. **Family loop (30s).** Switch to Mark's phone: the alert arrives with **Call Mom**.
4. **The coach (45s).** Dorothy taps the mic: "How do I block this number?" Step-by-step cards walk her through it.
5. **The bigger picture (30s).** Learn tab: StartHere doesn't just block scams, it builds confidence with AI. Close on the name: StartHere.

Developer handoff notes

- Build mobile-first with one codebase (React Native or Flutter) so iOS and Android ship together.
- The share sheet extension ("Share to StartHere") is the most important entry point; build it early.
- Verdicts come from one AI service returning: verdict, scam type, signs (max 3), risk flags (money, code, gift card, impersonation), next steps. The UI only renders this; no verdict logic in the front end.
- Store check content on the device by default; send only what's needed for analysis.
- Text sizes and colors as design tokens so the 3 size presets and dark mode come free.

Open questions

- [ ] Can the app screen incoming calls, or only things she forwards and describes? (Platform limits differ on iOS and Android.)
- [ ] Free, paid by the senior, or paid by the family member?
- [ ] Which AI provider powers the Coach and Checker, and what's the privacy policy wording?
- [ ] Is a Spanish-language version in scope for MVP?